10. The Flood Everyone Knew

Passage: Genesis 6:9–9:29 (the whole Flood narrative, with its doublets marked · the last verses, 9:18–29, with notes on the Hebrew)

A note before we begin

Some of us first met *Gilgamesh* as an argument against the Bible: here is the story of Noah, written down long before Genesis, with a different hero and a crowd of gods. Some of us met the opposite argument: every culture on earth remembers a great flood, so Genesis must be true. Today takes both seriously — and finds that both are looking in the wrong place. Both rest on the outline: rising water, a boat, a few survivors. To the first people who heard Genesis, the outline was not the news. They lived in a world where the flood story was already being told. What they had not heard was *this* telling of it.

If it unsettles you that Noah's story has older cousins, that is an honest response, and you are in good company; it unsettled a great many people when the first flood tablet was deciphered in 1872. If it unsettles you that "every culture has a flood story" turns out to be less true than is often said, that is honest too. Faithful readers explain the likeness in more than one way, and this session lays them out. But however you explain it, today's claim is the same: **the meaning is in the details, and the details are where Genesis is different.**

Aim of this session

Three movements: **the story everyone knew** — *Atrahasis* and *Gilgamesh* set beside Genesis; **where Genesis breaks the pattern** — nine places, from why the water came to what God remembers; and **floods around the world** — a chart of flood stories from every inhabited continent, and what their details show.

Part 1 — The story everyone knew

You have met both stories before. In **Session 1** we read the opening of ***Atrahasis***, the Babylonian epic in which the gods make humankind out of clay to carry their labour; its oldest dated copy was made around 1635 BCE, and its climax is a flood. In **Session 8** we met **Gilgamesh**, the king who wanted a name. In Tablet XI of his epic, afraid of dying, he finds the one man who survived the flood and was given eternal life, **Uta-napishti** — and the survivor tells him how. Tablet XI took its flood from *Atrahasis*; it even slips and calls its hero "Atra-hasis."

These stories travelled. Copies of *Atrahasis* have been dug up in Babylonia, at Ugarit on the Syrian coast, and at the Hittite capital in Turkey; a piece of *Gilgamesh* turned up at Megiddo, in Canaan. No flood tablet has been found in Israel itself, so the careful claim is this: **the story was in the air of their world**, told and copied across the ancient Near East for well over a thousand years. And Genesis's own details suggest its writer knew it — the mountain, the birds, the altar, the aroma, and one word. The *pitch* of 6:14, ***kōper***, appears nowhere else in the Bible, and it matches the Babylonian *kupru*, the pitch on Uta-napishti's boat. S. R. Driver, in 1904: *"it is possible therefore that kōpher came into Heb., with the story, from Babylonia."* (Possible: bitumen was traded, and a word can travel without a story. The cluster of details is the stronger evidence. How the writer knew it is the second question below.)

Listen to how much the stories share.

	Gilgamesh XI	Genesis
The decision	*"The great gods, brought their hearts to send a deluge"* (XI 14)	*"I have decided that all living creatures must die"* (6:13; literally, *"the end of all flesh has come before me"*)
A boat	*"Tear down the house, build a ship!… Bring into the ship the seed of life of everything!"* (XI 24–27)	*"Make for yourself an ark of cypress wood"* (6:14)
Pitch	*kupru* (XI 55, 66)	*"cover it with pitch inside and out"* (6:14)
Who goes in	*"all my family and relatives. / The cattle of the field, the beast of the plain"* (XI 85–86)	*"you, your sons, your wife, and your sons' wives… two of every kind of living creature"* (6:18–19)
Everyone else	*"And all mankind was turned to clay"* (XI 135)	*"all living things that moved on the earth died… and all humankind"* (7:21)
A mountain	*"…the Ark on the Mountain of Nisir / Grounded"* (XI 142; the name is now read Nimush)	*"the ark came to rest on one of the mountains of Ararat"* (8:4)
Birds	a dove — *"It did not have a resting place; it returned"*; a swallow; a raven — *"it did not return"* (XI 147–156)	a raven; a dove — it *"could not find a resting place for its feet"* (8:7–12)
A sacrifice	*"I offered a sacrifice… The gods smelled the sweet savor"* (XI 157–162)	*"Noah built an altar… And the LORD smelled the soothing aroma"* (8:20–21)
Remembering	a necklace, to keep *"these days in remembrance"* (XI 165–167)	a bow: *"I will remember my covenant"* (9:15)

The likeness runs through both of the strands Session 9 traced: the pitch, the measurements, the mountain and the bow belong to the Priestly telling; the seven days, the birds, the altar and the aroma to the other. However Genesis was put together, the likeness runs through the whole.

Two questions

Did it happen? For this class the New Testament settles it: Jesus set the days of Noah beside his own coming (Matthew 24:37–39; Luke 17:26–27), and Peter set the flood beside the judgment to come (2 Peter 2:5; 3:5–7). Genesis itself tells it as history, with a family heading (*"This is the account of Noah,"* 6:9) and dates by the day of Noah's life (7:11; 8:13–14). Archaeology cannot settle it either way; the flood layers found in Mesopotamian cities are local and of different dates. What Christians who read it as history have not agreed on is **how far the water reached** — over the whole globe (*"all the high mountains under the entire sky were covered,"* 7:19; *"the world existing at that time was destroyed,"* 2 Peter 3:6), or a vast regional flood told in the language of "all," as Genesis can say a famine was *"severe throughout the earth"* (41:57). This session does not settle that; both views are on **floods around the world**.

How are the stories related? The New Testament settles *that* it happened, not this, and both answers are held by people who believe it did. But on whether Genesis drew on the Mesopotamian telling itself, they cannot both be right. **Genesis knew the Mesopotamian telling and answered it.** That Genesis drew on the Mesopotamian story has been the majority view since 1872, among churchmen such as the Anglican S. R. Driver quoted above; that it does so in order to *answer* it is a twentieth-century reading, developed by Jewish scholars such as Umberto Cassuto, Nahum Sarna and Tikva Frymer-Kensky. *Its strength:* the sharpest differences fall where the theology is at stake. *Its hard question:* shared details do not prove copying, and not every difference is a rebuttal. **Neither copied the other; both draw on an older, shared tradition** — the view of the evangelical Assyriologist Alan Millard, who co-edited *Atrahasis* and argued that borrowing had yet to be shown (*Tyndale Bulletin*, 1967), and of Kenneth Kitchen. Gordon Wenham, also an evangelical, reads Genesis as *"a truly revolutionary work that fundamentally challenged the beliefs of that era,"* yet judged the parallels *"not so close that we can suppose the writer of Genesis borrowed from them or had even read them"* (*Word & World*, 1994): the answering, without the borrowing. *Its strength:* the tradition is very old — the Mesopotamians dated their history by the flood (the Sumerian King List, Session 7: *"Then the flood swept over"*) — and Genesis differs even where nothing theological is at

stake, as in the ark's shape and the order of the birds. *Its hard question:* the shared source has never been found, and the closeness of the details — the birds sent out in turn, the deity smelling the offering, a Babylonian word for pitch — looks to many like contact with the Mesopotamian telling itself. You may hold either.

On either answer, the comparison works the same way. If you had grown up on *Gilgamesh*, you would know where Genesis was going at every turn — and you would keep being surprised.

> **Talk about it.** Which of the shared details surprises you most? Imagine hearing Genesis for the first time with *Gilgamesh* already in your head. What would you be listening for?

Part 2 — Where Genesis breaks the pattern

1. Why the water came

In *Atrahasis*, people multiplied, and their noise kept the god Enlil awake: *"[Concerning] their clamor I am troubled."* He sent plague, then drought, then famine — and still *"[The people] have not become less; they are more numerous than before."* So he sent the flood. *Gilgamesh* gives no reason at all: *"The great gods, brought their hearts to send a deluge."*

Genesis gives a reason, and gives it twice (Session 9): the human **heart** — *"Every inclination of the thoughts of their minds was only evil all the time"* (6:5) — and **violence**: *"the earth was filled with violence"* (6:11). The word is ***ḥāmās***: what people do to one another. Genesis knows the other worries too. Its flood story opens *"When humankind began to multiply on the face of the earth"* (6:1), with heavenly beings crossing a line (6:2–4, Session 8). But in Genesis multiplying is the blessing (1:28), never the offence. (Scholars debate what the noise in *Atrahasis* means — too many people, many think; some, humans pushing into the gods' own sphere. Either way, it is not what Genesis names.)

2. Who is in charge

In Mesopotamia a council of gods decides, and swears an oath to keep it secret. Ea, the clever god, has sworn with them — so he does not tell a man; he tells the reed house the man lives in:

> *Nin-igi-azag—'tis Ea—, (albeit) conspirator with them, / Unto a reed-hut their counsel betray'd he: "O Reed-hut, O Reed-hut! Wall, wall! Hearken, O Reed-hut, consider, O Wall!" (Gilgamesh XI 19–22)*

And when the storm comes, the gods lose control of their own flood: *"The gods fear the deluge. / They withdraw, they ascend to the heaven of Anu. / The gods cower like a dog"* (XI 114–116).

In Genesis one God decides, warns, and saves. He opens *"all the fountains of the great deep"* (7:11), and he closes them (8:2). In the middle of the story, *"God remembered Noah… God caused a wind to blow over the earth and the waters receded"* (8:1) — a wind over the waters, as in Genesis 1:2. The flood is creation run backward, and God runs it forward again; Peter reads it the same way — an earth *"formed out of water and by means of water"* by God's word, then *"deluged with water"* (2 Peter 3:5–6). *"The LORD sits enthroned over the engulfing waters"* (Psalm 29:10). Mesopotamia splits destruction and rescue between two rival gods; Genesis puts both in one God — which is why, as we saw last week, the tension lives inside God's own heart.

3. What the hero told his neighbours

Uta-napishti asks Ea, *"[But what] shall I answer the city, the people, and the elders?"* Ea gives him a cover story — *"[I kn]ow that Enlil hates me, and / I may not dwell in your city"* — and a riddle to tell them, which in our working translation runs: ***"In the morning, bread-cakes; at nightfall he will rain on you a shower of wheat."*** On the usual modern reading the words are deliberately double: the city hears a promise of plenty, and the rain that is coming is not wheat. Then he throws his workmen a feast *"like the Akitu festival,"* and sails.

In Genesis, Noah never says a word. Read the whole Flood story and notice who speaks: from 6:13 to 9:17 it is always God. Noah does not answer, ask, argue or warn. What the narrator says instead is *"And Noah did all that God commanded him—he did indeed"* (6:22). His first recorded words in the Bible come after it is all over, in 9:25. Genesis records no

word of his to his neighbours; the New Testament fills the silence. Peter calls him *"a herald of righteousness"* (2 Peter 2:5), so he proclaimed; Hebrews adds that by building the ark in faith *"he condemned the world"* (11:7); and *"God patiently waited in the days of Noah as an ark was being constructed"* (1 Peter 3:20). We read Genesis with them. The rabbis, filling the same silence, pictured him planting cedars and cutting them down for a hundred and twenty years so that people would ask: *"They said to him: 'Why are you doing this?' He said to them: 'So said the Master of the world, that He is bringing a flood upon the world'"* (*Genesis Rabbah* 30:7). The god of *Gilgamesh* helps his man keep the city in the dark. The God of the Bible waits.

Why him? The names say it. *Atra-hasis* means "exceedingly wise"; *Uta-napishti*, "he found life." *Gilgamesh* gives no reason for choosing him at all (the older Sumerian story does call its hero "humble… reverent"). Genesis: *"Noah found favor in the sight of the LORD"* (6:8) — grace first, then *righteous* (Session 9).

4. A box with no rudder

Uta-napishti's boat is a **cube**, 120 cubits each way, with six decks. He loads it — *"With all that I had of silver, I loaded it. / With all that I had of gold, I loaded it"* (XI 81–82) — and his craftsmen, and he hands it to a pilot: *"To the master of the ship, to Buzur-Amurru, the sailor, / I entrusted the great house, including its possessions"* (XI 95–96).

Noah's ark is a ***tēbâ***, a box — 300 by 50 by 30 cubits, a long, flat barge. It carries no silver and no gold: a family, the animals, food. There is no word in the story for a rudder, an oar, a sail or a pilot. *Tēbâ* appears in only one other place in the Bible: the basket, sealed with bitumen and pitch, in which a mother set her baby among the reeds of the Nile (Exodus 2:3, 5). Both times God keeps the future safe on the water, in a box no one steers.

5. Hungry gods

Why do the Mesopotamian gods care whether anyone survives? Because in *Atrahasis* (Session 1), humankind was made to do the gods' work — including feeding them. With the people drowned, the gods go hungry. In our working translation of *Atrahasis*, *"The Anunna, the great gods, sat in thirst and in hunger"*; *"like sheep they crowded the trough."* So when the survivor offers his sacrifice:

> *The gods smelled the savor. / The gods smelled the sweet savor. / The gods like flies gathered about the sacrificer. (Gilgamesh XI 161–163)*

Genesis keeps one line and drops the rest. *"And the LORD smelled the soothing aroma"* (8:21). *Soothing* is ***nîḥōaḥ*** — the sound of Noah's name again, and the first of forty-three times the Bible uses it; all but one of its later uses in the Torah are in the laws of sacrifice. No flies, no hunger, no meal. What follows the aroma is a **promise**: *"I will never again curse the ground because of humankind, even though the inclination of their minds is evil from childhood on. I will never again destroy everything that lives"* (8:21). The diagnosis of 6:5 is unchanged; the verdict is the opposite. The flood fixed nothing in the human heart, and God promises anyway. Israel would sing it later: *"Even if I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and all it contains belong to me. Do I eat the flesh of bulls?"* (Psalm 50:12–13).

6. Who grieves — and who objects

In *Gilgamesh* the mother goddess weeps **during** the flood, for what she herself agreed to:

> *The lady of the gods wails with her beautiful voice. / The former day is verily turned to clay. / When I spoke evil in the assembly of the gods… (XI 118–120)*

Afterwards Enlil sees the boat and is furious: *"Has anyone come out alive? / No man shall survive the cataclysm."* And Ea rebukes him — *"On the sinner place his sin; / On the evil doer place his crimes"* (XI 185–186).

Be honest about this one. The Babylonian story voices the objection readers have always felt: *why punish everyone?* Genesis's own answer is that this was not a world with a few sinners in it — *"all living creatures on the earth were sinful"* (6:12) — and that the one righteous household was spared (7:1). That answer takes in the animals, and it is hard to stretch

over the children, as Session 9 admitted. (Ea's alternatives — a lion, a wolf, a famine — would still fall on guilty and innocent alike.)

In Genesis no human objects. But what Ea pleads for, God says to his own heart: *"I will never again destroy everything that lives, as I have just done"* (8:21) — and on a different ground from Ea's, not "punish only the sinner" but *"even though the inclination of their minds is evil."* In Babylon it took a second god to say it; in Genesis it is the God who sent the flood. And the human protest will come — from Abraham, at Sodom: *"Will not the judge of the whole earth do what is right?"* (18:25). God listens; the bargaining stops at ten; Sodom still falls, and Lot is brought out (19:29). Jesus sets the two stories side by side to warn how suddenly judgment comes (Luke 17:26–30), and Peter concludes that *"the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from their trials"* (2 Peter 2:9). Ezekiel names Noah again when he raises the question for his own day: in a land that sins, even Noah, Daniel and Job *"would save only their own lives by their righteousness" — "they could not save their own sons or daughters"* (14:14, 16), though in Genesis Noah's sons were saved with him (7:1). Each answers for himself, and God insists that his judgments are *"not without reason"* (14:23). The question may still be asked; Abraham asked it, and God listened.

7. A god, or a man of the soil

In *Gilgamesh*, the god who sent the flood comes aboard and blesses the survivors:

> *Now, indeed, Uta-Napishtim and (also) his wife shall be equal / Like to us gods; in the distance afar at the mouth of the rivers Uta-Napishtim shall dwell (XI 203–206)*

The Sumerian hero is given *"life like a god"*; Berossus's is *"gone to live with the gods."* God blesses Noah too (9:1) — but the blessing is different: not eternal life for one couple, far away, but *"be fruitful and multiply"* for everyone. And notice who is raised with Uta-napishti: his wife. Noah's wife and his sons' wives are never named and never speak (later Jewish writers gave her a name — *Jubilees* calls her Emzara).

Genesis: *"Noah, a man of the soil, began to plant a vineyard"* (9:20). The ground, cursed since 3:17, yields again — the hope his father spoke when he named him *Rest, "because of the ground that the LORD has cursed"* (5:29). Session 7 promised this would land here. It lands with a sting: the first harvest is wine, and Noah gets drunk and lies uncovered in his tent (9:21). And *"The entire lifetime of Noah was 950 years, and then he died"* (9:29) — the refrain of Genesis 5 returns. Genesis will not make a god of its survivor. Scripture still honours him — for his faith, not his perfection (Ezekiel 14:14; Hebrews 11:7) — but the hero of this story is the God who remembered him.

A note on 9:25. *"Cursed be Canaan!"* — Canaan, Ham's son, not Ham; and it is Noah who says it, waking from wine. God curses no one here. The rabbis asked the question: *"Ḥam committed the sin and Canaan was cursed? This is astonishing"* — one answered that God had already blessed Noah's sons (9:1), another that Canaan himself had seen and told (*Genesis Rabbah* 36:7). The same midrash also keeps folk-tales of Ham emerging from the ark "darkened" and of Canaan "darkened" by the curse, and the Talmud says Ham was "afflicted in his skin" (*Sanhedrin* 108b) — stories that make dark skin a punishment, troubling in themselves, but not arguments for slavery. Centuries later, in the Islamic and Christian Near East and then in Europe and America, such tales were fused with this verse into a "curse of Ham," used to justify enslaving Black Africans and preached in America in defence of slavery and segregation. The text says no such thing. The chapter itself answers it: every human bears God's image (9:6), and *"from them the whole earth was populated"* (9:19) — every nation *"from one man"* (Acts 17:26). The Spanish-born Abraham ibn Ezra saw through it in the twelfth century: *"There are some who say that the Cushites are enslaved because Noah cursed Ham. However, they have forgotten that the first king to rule after the flood was a Cushite."* Many churches that once taught it have renounced it — the Southern Baptist Convention formally in 2018. More on **Noah among his readers**, and next week, when Noah's sons become the nations.

8. Fewer people, or more?

Atrahasis's gods had tried drought and famine against humankind before the flood. Genesis's God promises the opposite: *"While the earth continues to exist, planting time and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, and day and night will not cease"* (8:22). And *Atrahasis* ends with the gods solving the problem of humankind for good. Its last column (in our working translation) orders: *"let there be a third (category) among the peoples: among the peoples, the woman who gives birth, and the woman who does not give birth. Let there be among the peoples the Pāšittu (the 'Obliterator'); let her seize the baby from the lap of the one who bore it"* — and orders of priestesses who may not bear children. **Fewer people**, so that the gods can sleep.

Genesis:

> *Then God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth." (9:1)*

It is the blessing of 1:28, word for word — and God says it twice (9:1, 9:7). Two words of Genesis 1 are missing: *subdue* and *rule*. In their place, the animals will fear us (9:2). And then the law:

> *"Whoever sheds human blood, by other humans must his blood be shed; for in God's image God has made humankind." (9:6)*

Frymer-Kensky saw the shape of it. *Atrahasis* answers its flood with fewer births. Genesis answers its flood — which came because of violence — with more people, and a law that protects each one, because each bears God's image. Rabbi Akiva: *"Anyone who sheds blood, it is considered for him as though he has diminished God's image"* (*Genesis Rabbah* 34:14). Judaism calls the laws binding on every nation "the seven commandments of the children of Noah"; it reads most of them out of God's command to Adam, with this chapter's ban on flesh with its life in it (9:4) added for Noah (more on **Noah among his readers**, §4).

9. What each one remembers

The goddess lifts a necklace of lapis lazuli beads carved as **flies** — in *Atrahasis* the drowned became like flies, and the gods swarmed the sacrifice like flies — and swears by it:

> *'O ye Gods! I will (rather) forget (this) my necklet of sapphires, / Than not maintain these days in remembrance, nor ever forget them. (XI 165–167, Thompson)*

(Last week's handout quoted an older translation of this line; modern editions read it as here.)

God says: *"I will place my rainbow in the clouds"* (9:13). The Hebrew says *my **bow** — **qešet***, the word for an archer's weapon in 72 of its 76 uses in the Bible, including God's own (*"He has prepared to shoot his bow,"* Psalm 7:12). In Babylon's creation epic (Session 1), Marduk's war-bow is set in the sky as a star after his battle. Many readers have heard the same picture here: Josephus called it *"the bow of God,"* and Nachmanides, in the thirteenth century, passed on earlier commentators' picture of a bow turned away from the earth — *"It is indeed the way of warriors to invert the instruments of war which they hold in their hands when calling for peace from their opponents."* Others think *bow* simply describes the shape.

And the bow seals something new: the first thing the Bible calls a **covenant**. The word first appears at 6:18, as a promise made before the rain; here it comes seven times in ten verses (9:8–17), and the partners keep widening — *"you and your descendants… every living creature that is with you"* — until it is *"between me and the earth"* (9:13). The animals are named partners, not cargo. The promise has no conditions; the laws of 9:1–7 come before it, not as its price. And the sign is for God to look at: *"I will notice it and remember the perpetual covenant between God and all living creatures"* (9:16). The goddess remembers her grief. God remembers his promise — and recalled it himself to Isaiah's exiles: *"this is like in Noah's time, when I vowed that the waters of Noah's flood would never again cover the earth… my devotion will not be removed from you"* (Isaiah 54:9–10).

The same story, a different God

Not every difference is an argument; some are simply what the story looks like when it is told by people who worship one God. But together they say a great deal.

	The neighbours	Genesis
Why	the people's noise; or no reason	violence; the heart
Who decides	quarrelling gods, under oath	one God
During the flood	gods terrified and hungry	*"God remembered Noah"*
The neighbours	a cover story	no recorded word — and, in 2 Peter, a herald
The boat	a cube, a pilot, silver and gold	a box with no rudder
The sacrifice	gods "like flies"	a soothing aroma — and a promise
Who objects	Ea: punish the sinner, send a plague instead	God himself, to his own heart (8:21); later Abraham
The survivor	made a god	a man of the soil, who dies
Afterward	fewer births	*"be fruitful"*; every human life protected
Remembering	a necklace of flies	a bow in the cloud; a covenant with all life

> **Talk about it.** Which of the nine differences says the most to you about God? And sit for a moment with number 6: a Babylonian god objects to the flood on moral grounds. What do you make of Genesis's answer — and of the fact that when Abraham objects, God listens, and Sodom still falls?

Part 3 — Floods around the world

"Every culture has a flood story." It is not quite true. Flood stories are found on **every inhabited continent** — but **not in every culture**. They are common in South and Southeast Asia, the Pacific and the Americas. They are rare in Europe, missing from ancient Egypt, absent in the Noah sense from the classical books of China and Japan, and nearly absent from Africa. Sir James Frazer, who collected hundreds a century ago, wrote: *"In Africa, including Egypt, native legends of a great flood are conspicuously absent; indeed no single clear case of one has yet been reported."* Later collectors found more, but few with Noah's shape.

Here is a sample, with the oldest record of each. The full chart, with twenty-six stories besides Genesis, is on **floods around the world**.

People (first written down)	Why the water came	Who survived — and why	What came after
Babylonia, *Atrahasis* (c. 1635 BCE)	the people's noise	Atrahasis, "exceedingly wise"	the gods gather "like flies"; fewer births
Egypt, *Destruction of Mankind* (c. 1325 BCE)	rebellion against Ra — a slaughter, not a flood	everyone left: Ra relents and makes the goddess drunk on red beer	Ra withdraws, weary of people
India, Manu (8th–6th c. BCE)	none given	Manu — he had saved a fish	a sacrifice; a woman born of it; *"rich in offspring"*
China, Gun and Yu (4th c. BCE and earlier)	none given	no one in a boat: Yu *drains* the flood	a law for good government
Greece, Deucalion (468 BCE; Ovid, 8 CE)	the race's wickedness	Deucalion and Pyrrha, the most righteous	a sacrifice; stones thrown over the shoulder become people
Innu and Anishinaabe (Ojibwe), Canada and the Great Lakes (1633; 1839)	a feud with the water-spirits	the hero (Messou; Nanabozho), who caused it	a muskrat dives for mud; the earth is remade
K'iche' Maya, *Popol Vuh* (1550s)	the wooden people forgot to thank their Maker	no one	humans remade from maize

People (first written down)	Why the water came	Who survived — and why	What came after
Nahua (Aztec) (1558)	the end of an age	Tata and Nene, sealed in a log by a god	their cooking smoke angers the gods; they become dogs
Inca (1572)	pride and covetousness — the Spanish writer's words?	a man and a woman in a box	Viracocha remakes the nations from clay
Gunaikurnai, Victoria, Australia (1878)	a frog is made to laugh, and spills the water he swallowed	people saved in the Pelican's canoe	how pelicans got their colours
Hawai'i (1823 → 1878)	(none recorded → sin)	two people on Mauna Kea → Nu'u and seven others in a houseboat	(none recorded → a sacrifice and a rainbow)
Fiji (1840s)	two boys killed the god's pet bird	the rebels themselves	canoes kept ready for the next flood

Now ask of every story the same questions. Does it have this detail in its **earliest** full record? (● yes · ○ partly, or only later · blank, no)

	Gen.	Mesop.	Greece	India	China	Maya	Nahua	Innu, Anishi-naabe	Gunai-kurnai	Hawai'i 1823
The outline										
Water destroys nearly everyone	●	●	●	●		●	●	○	○	●
Someone is warned beforehand	●	●	●	●			●			
A vessel	●	●	●	●			●	○	●	
Animals saved with them	●	●	○	○				○		
Birds sent to test the water	●	●	○					○		
A mountain	●	●	●	●				○		●
A sacrifice afterwards	●	●	●	●			✕			
Genesis's meaning										
A moral cause	●	○	●			●				
One God, acting alone	●									
God grieves *before* the flood	●									
The survivor chosen as righteous	●	○	●							
"Never again," sworn as a covenant with all life	●									
A sign in the sky	●	○								
"Be fruitful and multiply," again	●			○						
Human life protected, because it bears God's image	●									
Other stories' meanings										
The gods need humans to feed them		●	○							
The survivor is made immortal		●								
Animals warn or rescue the survivors				●				●	●	
Humankind remade from new material			●	○		●	●			
It will all happen again			●	○			●			

(Greece: the full story is in Ovid and Apollodorus; its late pairs of animals and dove are marked ○, and Ovid's Jupiter knows the world is fated to end by fire. Nahua ✕: the survivors' smoke angers the gods. Hawai'i is the 1823 record. Notes for every cell are on the sheet.)

What the chart shows — and what it cannot. The middle band is built from Genesis's own details, so Genesis fills it by construction; build the rows from *Gilgamesh*'s details, or the Maya's, and Genesis has blanks too — the last band does exactly that. So the chart cannot prove that Genesis is more original; every story is distinctive in its details. What it shows is **what Genesis says that the others do not.** The outline — water, a warning, a boat, a mountain — is common, and its fullest form clusters in three traditions: Mesopotamia, Greece and India. A few echoes of Genesis's meaning are early and apparently independent — India's blessing of offspring, Ovid's righteous couple, the Maya's moral cause, which looks native though it was written down after the conquest. But the details that match Genesis most closely — pairs of animals, the dove, the rainbow, eight survivors — turn up outside the Near East **only in late Greek tellings that borrowed from the east, or in records made after missionaries arrived**. In 1823 a missionary in Hawai'i preached on Noah, and his hearers told him their own tradition, of two people saved on a mountain-top; *"they said they had never before heard of a ship, or of Noah."* By 1878 the version a Hawaiian convert gave — reading his people's story and Scripture as one — had a houseboat, eight survivors, a sacrifice and a rainbow. And several peoples expected the opposite of "never again": Plato's Egyptian priest, the later Hindu cycles, the Nahua, Fiji's canoe-keepers and Chile's Mapuche all looked for destruction to come again.

Why are there so many? Three answers, which can be combined (each is set out on the sheet). **One flood, remembered** — narrowly, a real flood in Mesopotamia behind the Near Eastern stories; widely, in a line begun by Josephus and held by many Christians since, the nations' fading memories of Noah. (The wider form's hard question: outside the Near East, the closest matches come late, or after missionaries, and Africa, where Genesis 10 sends Ham's sons, has almost none.) **Floods happen wherever people live** — a flood that fills one valley is the end of the world for those who live there; and Egypt, where the Nile rose gently, has no flood story at all. (Its hard question: why do so many reach for *all* of humankind?) **Stories travel** — in the ancient world, and with the Bible. (Its hard question: Maya art from before the conquest is read as showing a flood ending an earlier world.)

None of these answers decides whether Noah's flood happened. We believe it did because Jesus and the apostles speak of it, not because of how many peoples tell flood stories. The existence of flood stories proves less than both sides have claimed: it does not show that Genesis copied a myth, and by itself it does not prove Genesis true. **The outline was common property. The details were not.**

> **Talk about it.** Look at the middle band of the chart, and then the last one. If you had to explain to a friend what Genesis says about God using only the rows where Genesis stands alone, what would you say? And what do the other peoples' rows say about what *they* hoped and feared?

Next week

Genesis 10–11: Noah's three sons become the nations of the world — and the nations build a city and a tower, *"so that we may make a name for ourselves"* (11:4). Gilgamesh wanted a name too.

So what?

1. The first hearers lived in a world that knew the story. What was new was the God. Not a council that panics, starves and quarrels, but one God who grieves before he judges, remembers in the middle, and promises afterwards.

2. God needs nothing from us — and binds himself to us, and to every living thing, anyway. The gods of Babylon needed humans to feed them. The LORD smells the offering and answers with a promise, a covenant with *"every living creature"* and with the earth itself. Paul said it to the Athenians: God is not *"served by human hands, as if he needed anything"* (Acts 17:25).

3. After the flood, the answer to violence was more life, and every life protected. Babylon's gods solved the human problem with fewer births. Genesis answers with *"be fruitful and multiply"* and with a law of blood for blood, grounded in the reason no human life may be taken lightly: *"in God's image God has made humankind."* Lamech had boasted of vengeance seventy-sevenfold (4:24); here it is limited to one life for one life.

4. "Never again" — but not never. The bow promises a world held steady — seedtime and harvest (8:22) — while God waits. Jesus read the flood as a picture of his own coming: *"they knew nothing until the flood came and took them all away"* (Matthew 24:39). Peter says the present world is *"reserved for fire"* (2 Peter 3:7), and explains the delay: the Lord *"is being patient toward you because he does not wish for any to perish but for all to come to repentance"* (3:9). And he saw in the ark a picture of the church's rescue: *"In the ark a few, that is eight souls, were delivered through water. And this prefigured baptism, which now saves you—not the washing off of physical dirt but the pledge of a good conscience to God—through the resurrection of Jesus Christ"* (1 Peter 3:20–21).

> **Talk about it — to close.** *First:* the neighbours' gods remembered their own grief; the God of Genesis remembers his promise. What difference does it make which kind of God you pray to? *Second, this week:* when you see a rainbow, remember that the Hebrew word is *bow*, and say the blessing the Talmud gives for it (*Berakhot* 59a) — in the full form, "Blessed are You, LORD our God, King of the universe," then: *"Who remembers the covenant and is faithful to His covenant and fulfills His word."*
